

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN BURKINA FASO

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Burkina Faso is a landlocked Sahelian nation — military-led and gripped by insecurity across much of its territory — whose economy has shifted in a generation from the land to gold, and whose defining environmental struggles are the harms of a gold-mining boom and the advance of the desert upon the farms. Mercury and cyanide seep into the water and the land; hundreds of thousands now dig for gold to survive; and against the encroaching desert, Burkina's own farmers have pioneered some of the world's great feats of land restoration — the zaï pit and the stone bund that pushed the desert back — a real and celebrated achievement this guide honours. But the same gold that now feeds the nation also poisons its water and entangles its fragile peace, and its industrial concessions can take farmers' land. There is no swift or landmark community victory to point to, and much of the country is dangerous. But a community facing a harmful mine or concession is not without tools.

A community in Burkina Faso facing a harmful project — an industrial gold mine poisoning the water, a concession displacing farmers from their land — works with real, if constrained, tools, pursued through what still functions and never at the cost of anyone's safety. A large mining project is supposed to undergo an **environmental and social impact assessment** — a gate that can be pressed where it is skipped or defective. The **mining code's community provisions** — consultation, compensation, and the share of revenue owed to local development — give a community a legal handle. **Land and customary rights** protect the farmers' ground and require that the displaced be compensated. The **courts and the functioning institutions** can enforce these, where it is safe to reach them. The **foreign mining companies behind the industrial concessions** operate under **international standards and financiers** a case can hold them to. And the **international and regional frameworks, and the community itself**, carry the case where the state is fraught. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. The state is military-led and much of the country insecure, with armed groups active, so the work must run through what functions and avoid the conflict areas entirely. The gold is now the economy and entangled with the insecurity. And artisanal mining is a survival livelihood for hundreds of thousands — so the harm to be contested is the pollution, the displacement, and the industrial concession, never the poor who mine to live, who must never be met with mere repression. There is no swift or landmark victory to promise. So the work must protect everyone involved, centre on what is safe, and aim at the harm contested — a mine's assessment enforced, a community's land and compensation defended, the pollution documented and pressed — not an open defeat of the gold economy. Above all, protect the people.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You cannot defeat the gold economy or safely act in the conflict areas, and you must never punish the poor who mine to survive. What you can do is contest the specific harm — the pollution, the displacement, the industrial concession — through what still functions: force the mine through a real assessment, invoke the mining code's community provisions and the land rights, hold the foreign company to its standards, document the harm, and work through the functioning institutions, the international frameworks, and the community, safely, and protecting everyone.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Burkina Faso is a fraught, insecure setting, and honesty about that is the first discipline. This is not a fight you win by open confrontation in a conflict-torn state, nor by repressing the survival miners. It is a careful effort worked through what functions, whose realistic prize is a mine assessed, a community's land and compensation defended, and the pollution pressed — not an open defeat of the gold. Aim at that winnable harm, avoid the dangerous areas entirely, and treat the safety of everyone involved as the overriding rule.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

Power rests with a military-led state in a nation where much of the territory is insecure. But the decisions a careful effort can reach run through **what still functions**: the **mining and environment ministries and their assessment procedures**, the **courts and functioning institutions** where it is safe to reach them, the **foreign companies and financiers** behind the industrial mines, and the **international and regional frameworks and the safe communities**. Map who decides a project's fate, and where it is safe to act, before spending a week on it.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

An industrial mine needs an environmental and social impact assessment, a mining permit, and — in law — consultation and compensation for the communities it affects. The assessment and the consultation are the point of entry, where a documented case can press for a proper process, conditions, or the compensation owed. Beyond them lie the courts, the mining code's community provisions, and the foreign company's international standards. Enter always where it is safe, and never in the conflict areas.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the gold: which company holds the industrial concession, what foreign financiers stand behind it, and what standards they answer to. Follow the water and the land: what pollution the mining causes, and whose farmland the concession takes. Follow the code: what assessment, consultation, compensation, and local-development share the mining law requires, and where they were skipped. The leverage lies in the assessment, the code's community provisions, the land rights, and the foreign company's standards.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Oversight is fraught in an insecure state, but the environment ministry's assessment procedures, the courts where safe, the mining code's community provisions, the foreign companies' own standards and financiers, and the international and regional frameworks are the channels a careful case engages — holding each, where it is safe, to what the law and the standards require.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Burkinabè effort easily defeats a favoured mine, and honesty requires saying so — the state is fraught and the gold central. But the assessment, the mining code, the land rights, and the foreign company's standards are real, and a community can win a concrete result. The single most decisive move is **documenting the harm and grounding it in the assessment and the code**, because the functioning institutions and the foreign companies respond to a documented, legally-anchored case, and because the mining law owes communities consultation, compensation, and a share of the gold. The assessment is the sharpest gate; the code's community provisions the strongest handle; the foreign company's standards the

external lever. The realistic prize is a mine assessed or conditioned, a community's land and compensation defended, the pollution pressed — pursued safely, and never against the poor.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the mercury and cyanide in the water, the farmland taken, the displacement, the industrial concession. **What does it owe in law?** — an assessment, consultation, compensation, a local-development share. **Who stands behind it?** — the foreign company, the financiers, and the standards they answer to. **Which channel is safe?** — the functioning institutions, the courts where safe, the international frameworks, the safe communities. **How is everyone kept safe, and the poor not punished?** — the overriding questions, answered by avoiding the conflict areas and contesting the harm, never the survival miner. Pick the harm where the assessment or the code offers the clearest, safest handle.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case in layers, safely. **Layer one: the harm** — the water and land pollution documented, the farmland taken, the displacement, and the mining's footprint. **Layer two: the law and the standard** — what assessment, consultation, compensation, and local-development share the mining code owes, where they were skipped, and which international standards the foreign company answers to. **Layer three: the channel and the safety** — which functioning institution, court, or international body to reach, and the absolute discipline of avoiding the conflict areas, protecting everyone, and never targeting the survival miners. A case built on documented pollution and the mining code's own obligations — carried safely — is one the institutions and the companies must answer.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **harm record**: the water and soil pollution data, the mercury and cyanide evidence, the farmland taken and the displacement. Gather the **law record**: the mining code's assessment, consultation, compensation, and local-development requirements, and the concession's permit. Gather the **company record**: the foreign operator, its financiers, and the international standards they answer to. Gather the **channel record**: the functioning institutions, the courts where safe, the international and regional frameworks, the safe communities. Gather the **safety discipline**: confirm the work avoids the conflict areas, protects everyone, and never targets the poor who mine to live.

STEP 3: BUILDING THE COMMUNITY AND INTERNATIONAL COALITION

Build the coalition carefully and only where it is safe: the **affected farming and water-using communities**, whose land and health are at stake; the **functioning institutions and technical bodies** that can carry the assessment and the code; and the **international and regional frameworks and allies** who can reach the foreign company and its financiers. Frame the effort as the defence of Burkina's water and land, never as a party to the conflict or the politics; involve no one who could be endangered; avoid the armed-group areas entirely; and never turn the fight against the poor who mine to survive — win them as allies, not adversaries.

STEP 4: ASSESSMENT, MINING-CODE & INTERNATIONAL LEVERS — CONTESTING THE HARM SAFELY

Set expectations honestly: the levers are real but constrained by insecurity, and the prize is the harm contested, not the gold defeated.

The Assessment and the Land Rights

A large mine is supposed to undergo an **environmental and social impact assessment**, and **land and customary rights** protect the farmers' ground and require compensation for the displaced. Where the assessment is skipped or defective, or the land taken without due compensation, a documented case can press for a proper process and the redress the law owes.

The Mining Code's Community Provisions

The **mining code owes communities consultation, compensation, and a share of the gold's revenue for local development**. These are a real handle: a community can insist on the process, the compensation, and the local-development share the law requires — a concrete gain even where the mine proceeds.

The Foreign Company and International Standards

The **foreign companies and financiers behind the industrial concessions** operate under **international environmental and human-rights standards** a case can hold them to, and the **international and regional frameworks** add reach where the state is fraught. Pursued together — the assessment and land rights, the mining code, and the foreign company's standards — these levers contest the harm safely and win real redress, while protecting everyone and never punishing the poor.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case to each audience. **For the environment ministry**: here is a mine that skipped or failed the assessment your law requires, with the pollution evidence. **For the affected community**: here is the consultation, compensation, and local-development share the mining code owes you. **For the courts (where safe)**: here is the land taken without the compensation the law requires. **For the foreign company and financiers**: here is a project that fails the international standards you answer to. **The golden rule**: contest the harm — the pollution, the displacement, the industrial concession — never the poor who mine to live; frame it as the defence of water and land, never as party to the conflict; and protect everyone and avoid the dangerous areas absolutely.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media must be handled with care in an insecure state. Frame the story around the **water and land**: the defence of a community's water, soil, and farmland against pollution and displacement — never as a party to the conflict or the politics. Carry it through the functioning national channels where safe, the international environmental and human-rights outlets, and the regional networks. A few cautions govern everything: keep it strictly to water and land; never frame it as a party to the conflict or against the survival miners; protect everyone; avoid the dangerous areas; and let the documented pollution and the mining code's obligations carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message factual, framed around water and land, protective of everyone, and never targeting the poor.

8A — To the environment ministry: identify the mine, the pollution, and the assessment it skipped or failed, and request a proper assessment and conditions.

8B — To the mining ministry: set out the consultation, compensation, and local-development share the code owes the community, and request them.

8C — To the affected community: document the harm and the redress the law owes, and organise the claim safely.

8D — To the courts (where safe, through counsel): establish the land taken without due compensation.

8E — To the foreign mining company: ask how the project meets the international standards it answers to, with the evidence.

8F — To a financier: present the harm and ask how the financing meets the institution's commitments.

8G — To an international or regional framework: describe the pollution and displacement and request attention.

8H — To the international public: summarise the water-and-land case and ask for support, without exposing anyone or targeting the poor.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: document the pollution or the land taken; write the one-page case (the harm, the assessment or code obligation skipped, the redress owed); identify the safest channel — usually the environment ministry or an international framework. **The fastest-moving levers:** the assessment gate, the mining code's community provisions, and the foreign company's standards. **Emergency coalition-building:** reach the affected community and a safe technical or international ally first — safely and away from the conflict areas. Throughout, protect everyone and never target the survival miners.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is tilted by a military-led state, a gold-dependent economy, and pervasive insecurity. Recognise it and adjust the aim — not a defeat of the gold, but the harm contested and real redress won. Lean on the levers the tilt cannot easily reach: the mining code's own community obligations, the land rights, the foreign company's international standards, the international frameworks. And accept the honest limits — the mine may proceed, the areas may be unsafe — while still winning the assessment, the compensation, and the local-development share the law owes, and protecting everyone.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

Distinguish the ordinary tilt from capture — concessions steered to insiders, compensation pocketed, assessments waved through, gold entangled with armed interests. Where capture appears, respond only through the **safe channels**: the mining code's obligations, the courts where safe, the foreign company's standards and financiers, the international frameworks. Never through anything touching the conflict or the armed groups. **On safety and protection:** this governs everything. Burkina Faso is a fraught, insecure, military-led nation where much of the country is dangerous. Work through the functioning-institution,

international, and community channels, and only where it is safe; never expose or endanger anyone; avoid the conflict and armed-group areas entirely; frame the work as the defence of water and land, never as party to the conflict; and never punish the poor who mine to survive. Safety and that discipline are the first rules.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, and only where safe. The documented harm feeds the assessment challenge, the mining-code claim, and the foreign-company pressure at once; the community and international coalition organises carefully alongside; the media carries the water-and-land frame throughout. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, document the harm and the law's obligations, safely; **months two to six**, press the assessment, the mining code, the foreign company, and the international frameworks; **beyond**, secure the redress and the local-development share, and defend the win. The core discipline: water-and-land framed, worked through what functions, never against the poor, and absolute in protecting everyone and avoiding the dangerous areas.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Burkina Faso is a fraught, insecure ground, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim the gold economy can be defeated, or that the conflict areas are safe, or that a swift victory exists — none of that is true. It honours, plainly, a real Burkinabè achievement: the farmers who pushed back the desert with the zaï pit and the stone bund. And it claims something narrower and real: that a community facing a harmful mine or concession can contest the specific harm — the pollution, the displacement, the industrial concession — through what still functions; that the mining law owes communities an assessment, consultation, compensation, and a share of the gold; that land and customary rights protect the farmers' ground; and that the foreign companies answer to international standards a case can invoke. The levers are constrained by insecurity, the work careful and safe, and the prize is the harm contested and real redress won — not an open defeat of the gold. But in a fraught, gold-dependent Sahelian nation, that careful, water-and-land-grounded effort — worked through what functions, protecting everyone, and never punishing the poor — is not a lesser ambition. It is the responsible and effective one.